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(Belonging) Beyond the Body, Beneath the Meat

What makes one Human *more* than another? Is it the spatial presence of the Body according to personal, or social, limits? Or is it the presence of an abstracted Power – one that is vaguely recognized as beyond [our] control – an anti-melioric Power that whispers in our words and screams through our screens, [*that's just the way it is?*](#)

I think of this each time I hear or read the voice of another: both modes are in fact, materializations of our own Experience. Language, emotional, rationality, and morality are but few powers we possess when we Voice the Human Experience, although they often act in contradiction and conjunction with [our] social World. This concept is one that has been long contested; from the Athenian playwrights to a middle-aged Mom on Facebook (sorry, *correction* to Meta), there remains an overarching theme: who do we un/consciously perform [our] language for? What does this sense of *performance*, as it has been speculated time-and-time again, mean within the “cosmic” models of social Power? Do we see ourselves as [“inhabiting our entertainment,”](#) or as forces of Power that can “cancel” another Human when *too* much ‘human-ness’ is expressed, rather than the ‘branding’ or ‘selling’ of Existence?

In a space and time, plausibly the Metaverse himself, I find that it is of no surprise that [we] find that [“\[we\] have never been able to share so much of ourselves,”](#) and yet, “[we] have never felt more alone.” Regardless of any [self-reflection completed over the span of COVID-19 quarantines](#), there are many media-users who have yet to question the relations between Mind//Body//Screen. Within this realm of the Online Body, there resides a totalizing disillusionment that actively works to ‘characterize’ or ‘classify’ what another Human shares as *Existence*. We use our power – our language – to express emotionality, rationality, and mortality; to perform for the un/seen masses. An act of voice, that is concomitantly expressing Experience, yet devaluing the Body and the Meat that makes the Human form, due to [our] very language that is sanctioned to the mouths of ____.

Perhaps, I am based because of my engagements with the theoretical and philological. Perhaps, I am un/hopeful for the future, at least not for my time but maybe, we can create a

greater foundation for beyond by addressing the Now and alleviating the inequities of Existence. I am beginning to believe that the 21st century, and the evolution of techno-cultural understandings, has brought about an altered mode of impulse and differentiation. It has redefined the performative once more (i.e., Clifford Geertz, Judith Butler, &c.), in due-time, of course, as our audience has become bountiful, in quality and in capacity, for both positivity or negativity. The boundaries of the Real socio-cultural World and *also* real online domains have become blurred: where does the claim to the Human Experience reside, and what makes one *more* than another?

This question is not one left solely to debate in [our] time and space: it has been a constant question of authenticity, for what makes the latency of memory and the ways in which [we] communicate our inner-worlds grander than Another? In the *On the Trinity*, St. Augustine suggested that our “inner-world [should] not belong to the language of any nation,” and [instead it] should “come from the understanding which already existed in the memory but was latent there” (Olney 1998, 52). Kate Manne expresses that “[we] are [wronged bodies, not wrong ones](#),” and this is true. Bodies should be able to Exist, and explain that Existence, without shame or fear of self-infliction, nor with pressures from the external World. Health has been consumed by capitalistic motive and profits; true Health is determined by the Mind encapsulated by said Flesh. It is not the Body that is taboo – it is the language that swallows it whole. [We] have been described as “Wrong” – our dualistic methods of classifications inform [us] from multiple directions – but it is [our] language that can de/construct and generate the reparative.

French humanist François Rabelais (1552) located the “impulse for art” as [“squarely in the stomach.”](#) – “Sir Belly—is the true master of all the arts...To this chivalrous monarch [we] are all bound to show reverence, swear obedience, and give hono[u]r.” What does de/consumption make of us now? Swear[s] of obedience and honor are misplaced: it is [our] language that eats all of which surrounds us. If [“the only fit food for a man is half a lemon,”](#) it is of no wonder why we attack the fat Body and the expression of discomfort in Existence. The sheer speed at which time and space evades us in this taxonomically digitized World is ever compounded with the constant insistence to be *less* than. Do the hands that produce the finest lemons reap their sour pleasure; or is that sickly sweetness only privy to those who regulate it? Does it leave the rest of [us] re-posting, [“is lemon coffee healthy?”](#)

Roxane Gay's 2017 novel, *Hunger*, depicts this contradiction and conjunction of language and the value of the Body: "I didn't know that I could give voice to my suffering when I did suffer" (Gay 15). Humans may continue to exist in space and time where [we] value presence, but that presence should be constructed by the words [we] attribute to our own Flesh, in kindness and in compassion – removed from the "meanness" brought about by consumerist mass-media, where value is constructed through the reactionary and quantitative view count. Humans can create a time and space where opinion can acknowledge the "the frustrating thing about cages," because [we] are all "trapped but [we] can see exactly what [we] want" (17).

There are parallels between the realms of language and the mouths that consume the social World around us. When will we be able to collectively communicate [our] Experiences as Humans without Another dismantling the very thing that gives space to [our] living?

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